



FROM SOMMELIER TO FINTECH FOUNDER

How a Nontechnical Founder Built and Launched Dime Time

A real-world journey through entrepreneurship, information systems, financial infrastructure and AI-assisted development

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U.S. Navy Veteran • MBA • Graduate degree in Management Information Systems

“Get out of debt, one dime at a time.”

A Nontraditional Path Into Technology

- U.S. Navy veteran
- Hospitality career in Las Vegas and Dallas
- Experience opening and operating high-profile restaurants
- Sommelier serving demanding, high-expectation guests
- MBA • Graduate degree in Management Information Systems
- Founder and builder of Dime Time

CORE MESSAGE

Technology founders do not all begin as software engineers.

Operational experience, customer empathy, discipline and systems thinking can become founder advantages.

Hospitality Was Founder Training

- Reading customer needs quickly
- Performing under pressure
- Communicating complex information clearly
- Building trust
- Recovering when something goes wrong
- Managing timing and operational details
- Delivering consistent experiences
- Working within high standards
- Leading without formal authority

A financial application also depends on trust, reliability, clarity and a carefully designed customer experience.

The Idea Began as an Academic Exercise

Business education turned an observation into a structured opportunity.

Entrepreneurship coursework introduced: problem definition, customer value propositions, market analysis, branding, business models, pitch development, financial planning.

Management Information Systems education connected business strategy to technology architecture.

Early academic work included the Dime Time concept, branding, color scheme, presentation materials and an initial outsourced demo.

IMPORTANT FRAMING

The early demo was not the final product.

It was a learning tool that transformed an abstract idea into something people could see and discuss.

THE PROBLEM

Why Dime Time Needed to Exist

- Many consumers intend to make extra debt payments
- Manual extra payments require repeated discipline
- Small amounts are easier to commit than large, irregular payments
- Everyday transactions can create a recurring behavioral trigger
- Automation can help translate intention into action

\$18.8T

U.S. household debt

\$1.25T

credit-card balances

91%

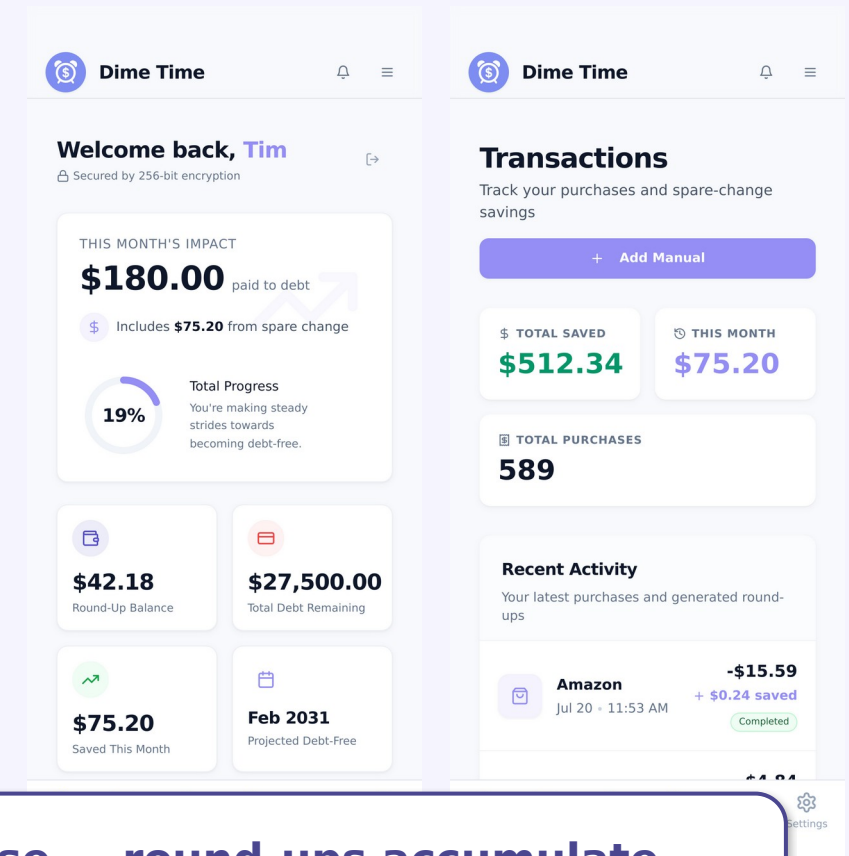
of U.S. adults own a smartphone

These figures describe the scale of the problem — they are not Dime Time metrics.

Sources: Federal Reserve Bank of New York, Household Debt & Credit Report, Q1 2026 (released May 2026) • Pew Research Center, Mobile Fact Sheet, 2025

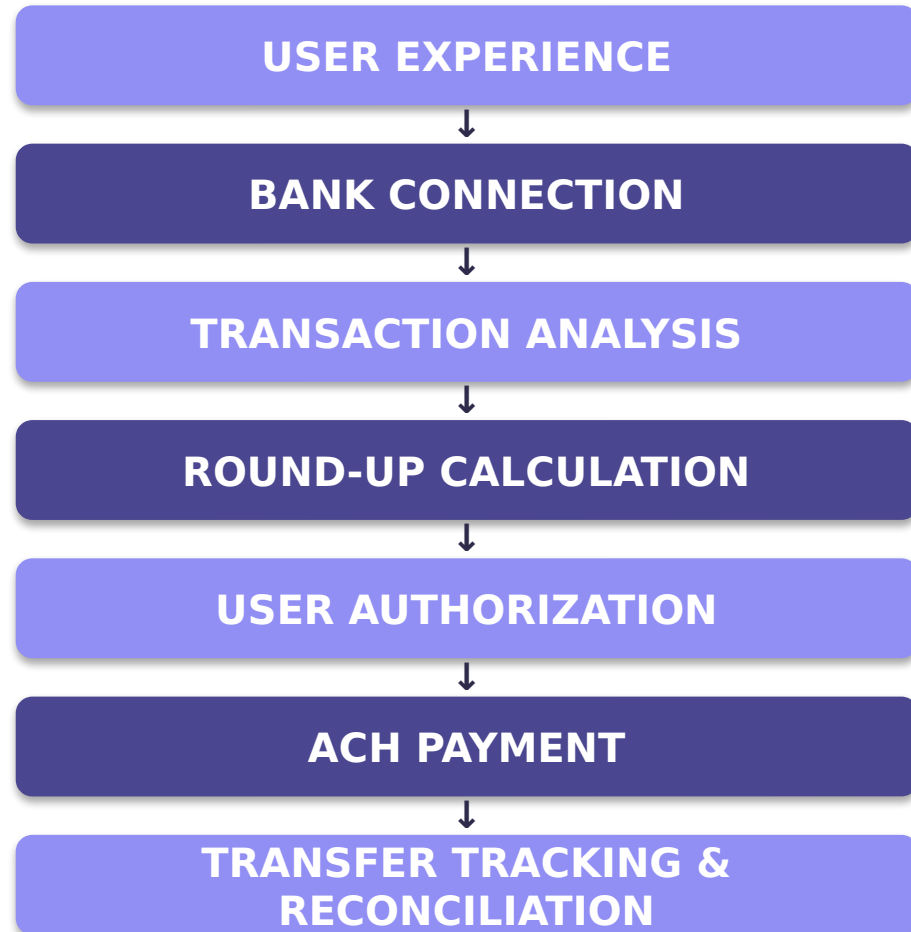
Get Out of Debt, One Dime at a Time

1. A user connects an eligible financial account
2. Everyday purchases are analyzed
3. Each purchase is rounded up
4. Round-ups accumulate
5. The user controls the destination and schedule
6. **Authorized ACH payments apply accumulated amounts toward debt**



Accuracy note: money does not move after every purchase — round-ups accumulate and transfer on a user-approved schedule.

A Fintech Product Is More Than an App Screen



Building Dime Time required:

- Mobile and web interfaces • authentication
- Database design • bank connectivity
- Transaction processing • ACH payment infrastructure
- User authorization records • security controls
- Transfer status tracking • error recovery
- Privacy and legal documentation
- App Store compliance

The app screen is the visible 10%. The other 90% is the system underneath it.

Learning to Build Without a Traditional Engineering Background

- Began with the business problem, not the programming language
- Learned how software components fit together
- Used AI-assisted development to accelerate learning and execution
- Broke large problems into smaller, testable tasks
- Learned to verify outputs instead of accepting them blindly
- Used screenshots, tests, logs and controlled experiments as evidence
- Developed enough technical literacy to make product decisions and question unsafe assumptions

CORE LESSON

AI can accelerate execution —

but it does not replace founder judgment, testing, accountability or domain understanding.

The System Behind Dime Time

FRONT END

- React
- TypeScript
- Capacitor mobile application

BACK END

- Express / Node.js
- PostgreSQL
- Drizzle ORM

FINANCIAL INFRASTRUCTURE

- Plaid — approved bank-connectivity products
- Stripe ACH
- Stripe Financial Connections — under review
- Mercury — business bank & payout destination

OPERATIONS

- Replit development environment
- Codemagic mobile build workflow
- Apple App Store
- Google Play preparation

Partner names indicate service relationships, not endorsements.

Building Financial Technology Means Building Guardrails

Master real-transfer switch

Separate ACH feature switch

**Founder-controlled user
allowlist**

No automatic public approval

First-transfer limit

Daily transfer limit

Transfer-frequency limit

User authorization evidence

Duplicate-payment protection

Webhook verification

Transaction ledger

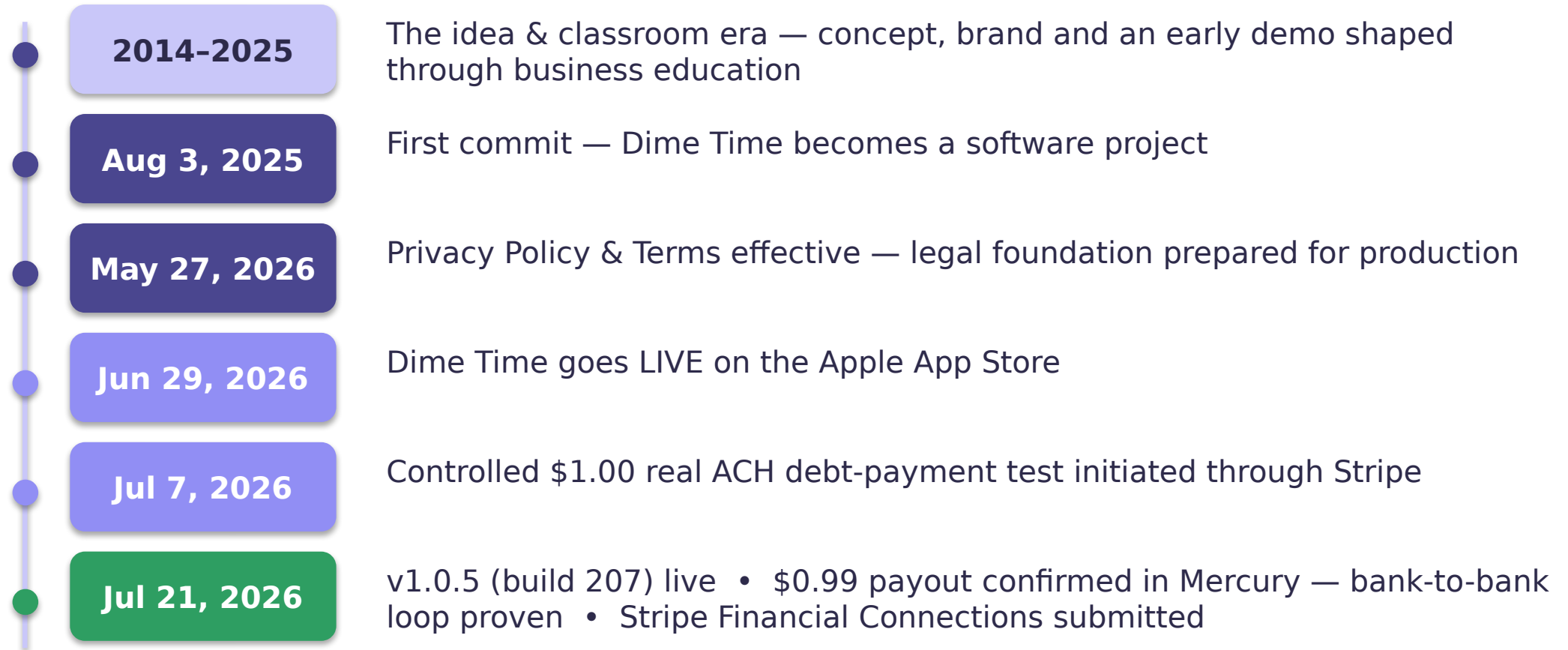
Audit logging

Plus: the ability to disable real transfers instantly.

In fintech, the safest successful test is more valuable than an uncontrolled launch.

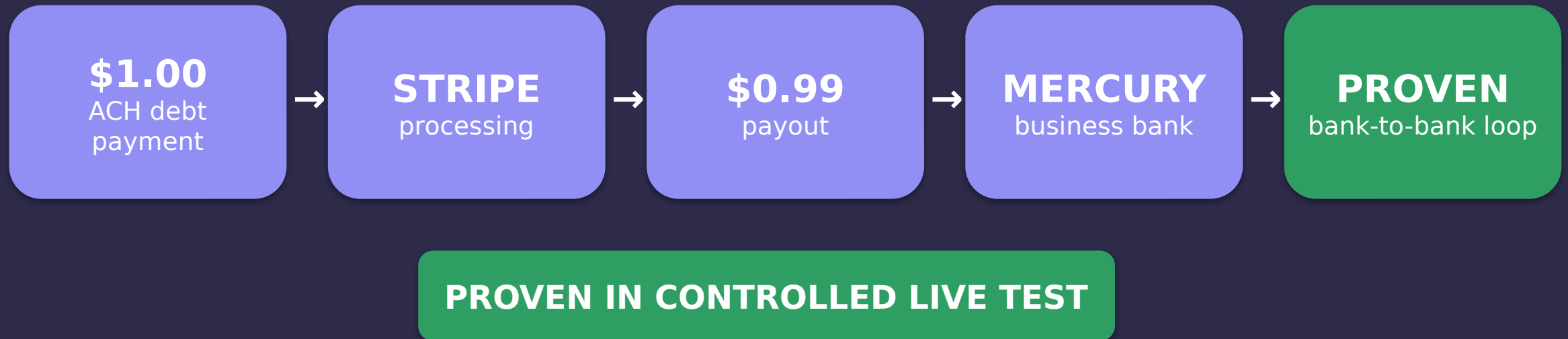
THE HISTORICAL TIMELINE

From Academic Concept to Live Fintech Product



Today: iOS live • rails proven in a controlled founder test • Google Play prep underway • public bank linking & debt import awaiting external approvals

One Dollar Changed the Project



- The amount was intentionally small — and the test used the founder's own controlled, allowlisted account
- The payment moved through real production rails; the payout confirmed the underlying system works
- **This did NOT mean public transfers were enabled — public bank linking still awaits external approval**

The Invisible Work Behind a Launch

- App Store reviews and resubmissions
- Resolving a duplicate-app rejection
- Payment-provider applications
- Bank-connectivity approvals
- Security reviews
- Legal documentation
- Email reliability fixes
- OAuth and universal-link work
- Mobile screenshot preparation
- Version and build management
- Android permission & signing preparation
- Waiting through third-party review queues

The public sees a launch date. The founder experiences hundreds of small decisions, failures, corrections and verification steps.

Every Failure Became a Better Control

CHALLENGE	RESPONSE	LESSON
App Store duplicate-app rejection	Removed the obsolete record and clarified the production app	Compliance problems require evidence and precise communication
Production email failures	Diagnosed delivery paths, corrected notifications, added tests	A feature is not working merely because the interface says it is
Real-money risk	Added feature switches, allowlisting, limits and audit controls	Safety must be designed before activation
OAuth return-flow issues	Added universal-link and resume handling	The complete user journey matters, not only the API call
Android permission risk	Removed permissions the product did not need	Minimize access and justify every permission

AI as a Force Multiplier, Not an Autopilot

WHAT AI HELPED WITH

- Explaining technical concepts
- Drafting implementation plans
- Reviewing code and configuration
- Generating tests
- Diagnosing failures
- Preparing documentation
- Structuring compliance checklists
- Accelerating iteration

WHAT STILL REQUIRED THE FOUNDER

- Choosing the problem
- Defining the product
- Making risk decisions
- Opening provider accounts
- Identity and business verification
- Reviewing financial behavior
- Running controlled live tests
- Deciding when NOT to launch
- Accepting responsibility for the outcome

The advantage is not access to AI — it is the ability to direct it, question it, verify it and combine it with real-world judgment.

What I Wish More Students Knew

1. You do not need permission to begin learning.
2. Your previous career may contain your founder advantage.
3. A prototype starts a conversation; a production system earns trust.
4. Learn enough technology to ask better questions.
5. Evidence is stronger than confidence.
6. Compliance is part of product design.
7. Small controlled tests beat large uncontrolled bets.
8. Do not confuse activity with progress.
9. External rejection is information, not identity.
10. Shipping creates opportunities that planning alone cannot.

“Your background does not disqualify you. It gives you a different set of raw materials.”

The Next Chapter

CURRENT ROADMAP — NOT COMPLETED MILESTONES

- Complete Google Play identity and organization verification
- Complete Android signing and first production build; test on real hardware
- Submit Dime Time to Google Play
- Receive Stripe Financial Connections approval → enable controlled public bank linking
- Receive Plaid Liabilities approval → verify automatic debt import
- **Begin controlled public user acquisition**
- **Measure activation, retention, ACH volume and subscription conversion**
- **Raise \$150,000 in pre-seed capital after launch milestones strengthen the story**

No guaranteed approval dates or launch dates — external review timelines are not ours to promise.



WHAT WILL YOU BUILD?

“Dime Time began as an idea about spare change. It became a lesson in persistence, systems thinking and turning education into execution.”

Tim Carlisle — Founder & CEO, Dime Time Technologies LLC

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Get out of debt, one dime at a time with Dime Time!

Fintech Terminology

ACH

The U.S. bank-to-bank transfer network; settles in days, not seconds

Bank linking

Letting an app securely connect to a user's bank account

Financial Connections

Stripe's product for verified bank account linking

Payment authorization

Recorded user consent before money moves

Idempotency

Ensuring a repeated request cannot cause a duplicate payment

Webhook

A provider's callback that reports events (like settlement) to the app

Feature flag

A switch that turns functionality on or off without redeploying

Allowlist

An explicit list of approved users — everyone else is denied

Production vs. sandbox

Real money and real data vs. a safe simulated environment

Settlement

The moment transferred funds actually arrive and are final

Classroom Discussion Questions

1. Which part of Dime Time's moat is technical, and which is operational?
2. When should a founder stop building and begin acquiring users?
3. How should a fintech balance speed with safety?
4. What should AI be trusted to do?
5. What evidence would you require before investing?
6. Which acquisition channel should Dime Time test first?
7. How would you define an activated user?
8. What ethical obligations come with automating financial behavior?

Verified Project Status

LIVE

- iOS v1.0.5, build 207 on the Apple App Store
- Core product interface
- Production access for approved Plaid products
- Stripe ACH infrastructure

PROVEN IN CONTROLLED LIVE TEST

- \$1.00 ACH payment
- \$0.99 Mercury payout
- Bank-to-bank financial loop

BUILT • FEATURE- GATED

- Core \$2.99 subscription functionality
- Real-transfer functionality behind safeguards

PENDING

- Stripe Financial Connections public bank-linking approval
- Plaid Liabilities approval
- Google Play launch process

PLANNED

- Coinbase / Bitcoin allocation
- Pro and Premium subscription tiers
- Broader public acquisition

Statuses are kept deliberately distinct — the honesty of the labels is part of the company's operating discipline.